to Professor Wendy Doniger's hefty 779-page book *The Hindus: An Alternative History*, published in 2009. This was the product of years of study and research by one of the world's leading and most respected Sanskritists, written in part so that those outside the Hindu tradition could, in Doniger's words, 'come to learn about it and admire the beauty, complexity and wisdom of the Hindu texts'.[29] Doniger's writing style is folksy and she has never been afraid of enthusing about what she has termed the 'glorious sexual openness' of some Sanskrit texts.

But this frank speaking led to protests from Hindutva organisations both in America and India, culminating in a lawsuit brought against the publishers, Penguin India, by a member of the RSS on the grounds that Doniger had violated his religious feelings under Section 295A of the Indian Penal Code. Under mounting pressure, Penguin India withdrew the book from sale, although I am pleased to report that the book is once more available in most bookshops.

It is not just Professor Doniger's work that is demonised. The scholarship of other respected North American academics is also under attack, most notably Steve Farmer, Richard Sproat and Michael Witzel on account of their work on the Harappa Civilisation and their painstaking deconstruction of some of the claims made by the 'out of India' theorists. So, too, are those academics who are deemed to have insulted a nationalist hero, as in the case of the American academic James Laine and his book on the seventeenth-century Maratha warlord and ruler Chhatrapati Shivaji.[30] When published in India in 2003 the book was interpreted by some hotheads as insulting to their prime Maharashtrian hero. An Indian historian who Laine had thanked in his acknowledgements was beaten up, and the renowned Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute in Pune, which had also had the misfortune to be thanked by Laine,